
40-YEAR-OLD FESTIVAL KICKS OFF IN OTTAWA

40-Year-Old Festival Kicks Off in Ottawa

The Winterlude Festival officially began on Friday in Canada’s capital, attracting an average of 600,000 visitors each year—and even more are expected this weekend.

Running from January 31 to February 17, 2020, Winterlude draws people from across the globe to Ottawa, Ontario, and Gatineau, Quebec. Known as one of Ottawa's most celebrated tourist events, it features a wide range of winter-themed attractions and activities for all ages.

This year’s highlights include:

- Rogers Town House Hockey Tournament
- Battle of the American Ice Carving Challenge
- Winter Pride
- Igloo Baratanga
- Canadian Ski Marathon
- Fire and Ice Winter Festival
- Ottawa Ice Dragon Boat Festival
- Gatineau Loppet

The festival aims to celebrate winter in Canada while promoting Canadian heritage, with organizers ensuring that all activities are free of charge. Events take place over the first three weekends of February, including Family Day (Monday, Feb. 18), across various sites in the Ottawa–Gatineau region.

Event Highlights by Date:

Feb 6 – Feb 9: Rogers Town House Hockey, Ice Carving Challenge

Feb 8 – Feb 9: Fire and Ice Winter Festival, Canadian Ski Marathon

Feb 6 – Feb 7: Ottawa Ice Dragon Boat Festival

Feb 5 – Feb 9: Winter Pride

Feb 1 – Feb 17: Igloo Baratanga, Gatineau Loppet

For more information, visit the official website: [Winterlude Canada](#).

Visitors’ Reactions

Visitors from across the region are already enjoying the festival.

“The ice sculptures are beautiful. We also enjoyed Griffin’s spinning rides for photos, and it’s been a perfect day for skating at the Rideau Canal because it’s so cold. We’re heading to Jacques Cartier Park for the kids’ slides and other fun tomorrow or over the weekend,” said Liz Crooks, who visited with her child.

“I think it’s really great—the ice sculptures are amazing! I love Confederation Park. The market was a little too crowded for me, so I’m curious to see how Sparks Street looks with the changes,” said Madelaine Morrison, who visited during her lunch break.

“The fresh air is what I like the most about this event. I’ve skated on the canal several times. I especially enjoy early morning skates at 11:00 a.m., and the fire buskers are very entertaining,” said Patrick St-Pierre, a tourist in Ottawa.

When asked what more he would like to see, St-Pierre replied:

“Maybe more circus performers and buskers today, I guess.”

Crooks added:

“I’m happy with what it is. We’ve been going for many years—it’s always fun, and there are always new things to see.”

